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Between Cold War Imperatives and State-Sponsored Terrorism: The United States and "Operation Condor"

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ABSTRACT
Operation Condor was a transnational network of organized state-sponsored terrorism that targeted Communist "subversion." It was operational in the second half of the 1970s. The key member countries were Chile, Argentina, Uruguay, Bolivia, Paraguay, and Brazil (Peru and Equador joined the network later on, with a more marginal role). Based on declassified documents from the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees in Geneva and on U.S. documents of various origin, this article will assess the development of the Condor network and the U.S. reaction to such manifest acts of state-sponsored terrorism.

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The U.S.–Latin American "Special Relationship"

The special nature of America's relations with its southern neighbors—recently defined as the "US-Latin American interstate regime"[1]—is rooted in President James Monroe's 2 December 1823 Annual Message to Congress. In announcing that any effort by the European colonial powers to extend their influence to the "Western Hemisphere" or "New World" would be considered dangerous to the peace and security of the United States, the American president set the parameters for future policies in the region. Following the rebellions in Latin America that had brought the Spanish rule to an end, what came to be called the Monroe Doctrine implied that the "Old World"—of monarchies and colonialism—and "New World"—of democracy and republics—had to be kept separate. From that moment onward, Washington's special relationship with Latin America evolved on the basis of the assumption that U.S. influence on the American continent was in some way natural and normal, considering the particular history of the United States and its mission to expand the newborn democratic ideals into territories threatened to be controlled by external (then European) powers.

With time the motivations of policies towards Latin America evolved. Geopolitical and economic interests gradually came to dominate Washington's worldview, but the Monroe Doctrine remained, in the subsequent American presidents' rhetoric, the formal justification for intervention. In the early twentieth century, Theodore Roosevelt's great power ambitions translated into the Roosevelt corollary to the Monroe Doctrine,

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and interventionism in Latin America, particularly during the presidency of Woodrow Wilson, became a central feature of American foreign policy. Some of the interventions included: aid to Panama in its separation from Columbia in 1903; installation of an American "economic advisor" in the Dominican Republic in 1905 (troops were then sent there between 1915 and 1934); the arrival of the U.S. Marines for the first time in Nicaragua in 1909 (they were then to return in 1912 and remain until 1927, helping to establish the Nicaraguan national guard).[2] Franklin Roosevelt's Good Neighbor Policy, initiated in 1933, marked a change from previous interventionist practices, emphasizing mutual agreements and goodwill in U.S.–Latin American relations. However, there was no doubt that the United States remained, throughout the 1930s and beyond, the undisputable senior partner and leader in the Western Hemisphere.

The sprit of cooperation in the name of "hemispheric unity" continued in the immediate aftermath of World War II. Both the Rio Pact of 1947, a mutual defense treaty between Latin American nations and the Unites States, and the creation of the Organization of American States in 1948, reflected the necessity to guarantee regional security that, from the Washington's standpoint, meant ensuring its hegemonic role. The American view point was effectively conveyed by Secretary of War Henry L. Stimson: "it's not asking too much to have our little region over here which has never bothered anybody."[3]

Latin America's strategic importance depended, in large part, also on the region's economic value. As a market for U.S. commercial exports, Latin America was as important as Europe, and more important than Asia, Africa, and Oceania combined. For example, by the late 1950s, private investments in Latin America reached about $6 billion, compared with direct private investments outside the Western Hemisphere that amounted to only $4.6 billion. Latin America was an equally important export market, as the countries of the region purchased about 50 percent of their total imports from the United States which, in turn, imported about 35 percent of goods—such as sugar, coffee, bananas, and wool—from Latin America. U.S. dollars then helped Latin American countries finance their purchase of industial equipment and military hardware from the United States.[4] Such economic interdependency obviously necessitated close political links between Washington and the governments of Latin America.

As the Cold War evolved, the defense of U.S. economic and security interests from perceived communist threats became the utmost priority for American foreign policymakers. Consequently, the maintenance of a U.S. sphere of influence in the region assumed an always greater importance. In May 1950, President Truman approved the National Security Agency (NSA) memorandum on "Inter-American Military Collaboration," which underlined that "the Cold War is in fact a real war in which the survival of the free world is at stake." Later in the same year, an American official statement declared that "US security is the objective of our world-wide foreign policy today" and "US security is synonymous with hemisphere security."[5] In the same period, George Kennan extended his strategy of containment to Latin America and outlined the main objectives of American policy:

1. the protection of our raw materials,
2. the prevention of military exploitation of Latin America by the enemy, and
3. the prevention of the psychological mobilization of Latin America against us.

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Communists "represent our most serious problem in the area" underlined Kennan, and they "have progressed to the point where they must be regarded as an urgent, major problem."[6]

During the 1952 presidential campaign, Dwight Eisenhower criticized the Truman administration for having disregarded Latin America, a region where economic distress had created popular unrest, which could be skillfully exploited by the communists.[7] Consequently, as president, Eisenhower intensified the tones of the anti-communist crusade and placed Latin America among the central areas of U.S. concern. A few years later, the intervention in Guatemala demonstrated the American determination to defend its interests in the region from (perceived or actual) communist threats.

Although there was no evidence of direct Soviet involvement, Washington's attention turned to the internal affairs of the relatively small Caribbean state because the nationalist and reformist government led by Colonel Jacobo Arbez Guzman had partially expropriated the holdings of the United Fruit Company, an American-based firm that traded tropical fruit (primarily bananas). Arbez rejected the demands for compensation and was, in general, unresponsive to U.S. pressure. Although the Guatemalan government included some communists, it was not controlled, nor led by communists. Nevertheless, Washington, undoutedly influenced also by the excecutives of the United Fruit Company, concluded that Guatemala was victim of Soviet expansionist influence. According to the U.S. leadership, the "cancer" of communism had spread to the American sphere and, therefore, had to be rapidly pushed back. The Eisenhower administration turned to the Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) for remedy. With a covert operation—code-named Operation PBSUCCESS—in 1954 the CIA orchestrated the coup that removed the (democratically elected) Guatemalan government and installed a military dictatorship led by General Carlos Castillo Armas. The country soon became one of the most repressive of the world. But, from Washington's perpective, it had won an important victory in the Cold War and at a minimal cost. The intervention in Guatemala was evidence of what could be accomplished by covert operations.[8] The thinking behind the intervention and the depth of the perceived communist threat emerges in a secret report of the CIA. These words not only seek to justify the necessity of action in 1954, but also set the course for future covert interventions:

> It is clear that we are facing an implacable enemy whose avowed oblective is world domination by whatever means and at whatever cost. There are no rules in such a game (…) long-standing American concepts of "fair-play" must be reconsidered. We must develop effective espionage and counterespionage services and must learn to subvert, sabotage, and destroy our enemies by more clever, more sophisticated, and more effective methods than those used against us. It may become necessary that the American people be made acquinted with, understand and support this fundamentally repugnant philosophy.[9]

The Kennedy administration attempted to approach Latin American affairs more constructively with the so-called Alliance for Progress. By promoting better economic conditions, the basis would be set for the development and promotion of democracy and this, in the long run, would advance U.S. interests in the struggle against the Soviet Union without the need to support authoritarian regimes. At the same time, however, President Kennedy continued to imploy covert means to deter or counter communist influence in the region. His administration implemented the plans, initiated under Eisenhower, to overthrow the Cuban government led by the revolutionary leftist leader Fidel Castro. The CIA had been

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training Cuban exiles for the invasion of their homeland in order to bring about a revolution that would depose Castro and reinstitute a government more closely alingned to U.S. interests. The covert plan was executed in April 1961, and was a clear-cut failure. While the CIA had predicted the uprising of the Cuban people against Castro, the revolt never occurred. The Bay of Pigs operation was thus an embarassing and humiliating defeat for the United States, which resulted only in increased domestic popularity of Castro and the strengthening of ties between Havana and Moscow, with the announcement of the formal Cuban–Soviet alliance in July 1961.[10]

Despite the Bay of Pigs fiasco, President Kennedy continued to rely on covert action to influence the orientation of Latin American governments considered too leftist. Only a few weeks after the Cuban debacle, Washington in fact focused on British Guyuna, which was heading for independence under a leader—Gheddi Jagan—whom the CIA assessed as potentially succumbing to the "same dark forces as Fidel Castro." In accord with the British, Washington successfully manuvered to leave Jagan out of the newly elected government that, from 1964 until the 1980s, was ruled by the authoritarian regime of Forbes Burnham.[11]

President Kennedy's determination to defend Washington's traditionally hegemonic role in the region was further confirmed during the Cuban missile crisis. As the crisis escalated, Kennedy stated:

> This secret, swift, and extraordinary buildup of Communist missiles—in an area well known to have a special and historical relationship to the United States and the nations of the Western Hemisphere, in violation of Soviet assurances and in defiance of American and hemispheric policy—this sudden, clandestine decision to station strategic weapons for the first time outside of Soviet soil—is a deliberately provocative and unjustified change in the status quo which cannot be accepted by this country.[12]

The president's successful management of the crisis, and the Soviet retreat from Cuba, underscored Washington's sphere of influence in the Western Hemisphere, even if Castro's regime remained in place and continued to pose an ideological threat to the United States.[13]

Therefore, with the coming and unfolding of the Cold War the nature of what had been conceived with the Monroe Doctrine and its successive evolution as an interstate regime for the defense from external influence gradually, albeit necessarily, changed. The United States hegemonic role extended itself well into the internal affairs of Latin American governments. On the basis of the assumption that "it is better to have a strong regime in power than a liberal one if it is indulgent and relaxed and penetrated by Communists."[14] Washington abandoned the idealistic justifications that had shaped the Monroe Doctrine in favor of clear cut anti-communism. In particular, after the 1959 Cuban revolution and the successive consolidation of Castro's regime, considered as a major challenge to U.S. regional hegemony, America's determination in defending its sphere of influence translated into open support for anti-communist and pro-American leaders, regardless of their undemocratic governments.[15]

Accordingly, in 1964 the Johnson administration tacitly supported the coup that ousted Brazilian President Joao Goulart and installed the authoriatian military government that ruled the country until the mid-1980s. The following year, Washington openly intervened in the Domincan Republic by dispatching a force of twenty-three thousand marines in order to prevent the return of Juan Bosch's government, assessed as too left-leaning. The initial explanation that the force had been used to protect the lives of American citizens was rapidly

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expanded to include the argument that action was necessary to block a communist take over in the Dominican Republic.

The defense of the American sphere of influence and the need to prevent the infiltration and expansion of communism remained the main justification for U.S. support for Latin American authoritarian regimes throughout the 1970s, when a number of coups swept the region, installing right-wing dictators in Bolivia (1971), Uruguay (1973), Chile (1973), and Argentina (1976). While in some cases American support was limited to granting recognition and legitimacy to the new regimes, in other cases—as most notably in Chile—the United States directly, although covertly, influenced the internal dynamics of the country. Washington had been concerned with the rise of Salvador Allende's influence in Chile since the 1960s, and had channeled support to the rival party led by Eduardo Frei in the elections of 1964. Six years later, however, the United States–CIA were unable to prevent Allende's victory. The Nixon administration considered this as a major threat to U.S. national security. In fact, as National Security Adviser Henry Kissinger later stated, it would have been difficult for the administration to accept "a second communist state in the Western Hemisphere." According to the Nixon White House, Allende would support Castrism and eventually form an alliance with the Soviet Union. Moreover, Kissinger worried about a potential domino theory in Latin America, as Chile bordered Argentina, Peru, and Bolivia, all "plagued by radical movements."[16] Although the exact role played by the United States in the military coup of 1973 that ousted Allende and brought to power the military dictatorship of Augusto Pinochet is still debated,[17] what is certain is that the United States immediately extended support to the new regime, despite the brutal killings, torture and imprisonment of political opponents.

By the mid-1970s U.S. support for right-wing dictators in Latin America was therefore a well-established and consolidated policy, grounded on the need to ensure that communism would not expand into the Western Hemisphere. But beyond the questionable—from a human rights perspective—support for such dictators as Hugo Banzer (who ruled in Bolivia from 1971), Alfredo Stroessner (who ruled Paraguay since 1954), Augusto Pinochet and, later, Jorge Videla (who came to power in Argentina in 1976), how far was the United States willing to go to protect its traditional sphere of influence in Latin America?

Operation Condor: An Anti-Communist Transnational "War Apparatus"[18]

Close links between the military structures of Latin American countries and the U.S. military and intelligence forces had been established in the early Cold War years. Resolute in preventing "another Cuba," the Kennedy administration further intensified these links and introduced a new mission for the combined military forces of Latin America. The new security doctrine was called Internal Defense and Development and encouraged the region's militaries to carry out intense anti-subversion campaigns in order to neutralize and defeat "internal enemies." From the American point of view, this entailed a major allocation of resources dedicated to creating or strengthening intelligence stuctures and counterinsurgency methods. The United States promoted the sharing of tactics and intelligence and provided training for Latin American forces in the context of a broad, anti-communist hemispheric security strategy.[19] The preexistence of these inter–Latin American intelligence relations facilitated the creation and operational effectiveness of the Condor network.

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After the 1973 coup d'etat in Chile, General Augusto Pinochet had dramatically tightened his control on the regime, with the capture and elimination of political opponents. In the months following the coup, the national stadium in Santiago had been used as a massive concentration camp with an estimated 40,000 political prisoners. A year later, the International Commission of Jurists, based in Geneva, published an account on the violations of human rights in Chile. The report stated that "in the four months, from May to August 1974, over 700 arrests of political suspects are known to have occurred. Half were released after approximately one month and half of these declared that they had been tortured." Most of these arrests were made by unidentified persons in normal clothes with guns, but without the arrest warrant required by the Junta's own decrees. Furthermore, the report continued:

> Apart from these individual arrests there have been mass arrests in the "poblaciones" (shanty towns) apparently designed to intimidate the population. (…) The usual procedure was for a "poblacion" to be surrounded, house to house searches carried out, and some hundreds of people arrested. 10,000 to 15,000 have been arrested in this way during the recent months. Most were released after 7–10 days. The remainder, between 500–1,000, were detained in a camp in the north. Officials of the Ministry of Interior have claimed that 75% of the "common criminals" so arrested proved to be members of the Communist Party, a ridiculous claim on any basis, but one which indicates the political character of these round-ups.[20]

While the report acknowledged that some arrests in Chile were still made by uniformed members of the military police, "by far the most are carried out by armed men dressed as civilians. These people may be members of Patria y Libertad, the extreme right group which operated during the time of Allende, but generally they belong to DINA (National Department of Investigations)."[21]

The role of the Chilean secret intelligence servives (the DINA), and of its leader Manuel Contreras, was in fact critical in the establishment of the terror regime in Chile. The DINA was a joint intelligence service of the Chilean armed forces and was not subordinated to any government ministry. It reported directly and exclusively to General Pinochet, and thus operated with a considerable margin of autonomy and independence. For these reasons, the people arrested could literally "disappear" for days or months without their detention even being recorded.

Against this background, in November 1975 Manuel Contreras hosted "the first inter-American meeting on national intelligence," inviting delegates from Argentina, Uruguay, Paraguay, and Bolivia to better coordinate their respective intelligence services so to more effectively carry out their missions. The meeting proved to be a success. In its formal closing statement the participants approved the creation and outlined the structure of a cooperative security organization designed to exchange information, bilaterally or multilaterally, on individuals or organizations considered dangerous for the security of their regimes.[22] As a first step, a "coordinating office"—the Office of Coordination and Security—would be created. This included a computerized data bank of suspects, "something similar to Interpol, but dedicated to subversion." The first meeting ended with a commitment to hold future working meetings in order to develop and expand the new organization, code-named CONDOR—after Chile's national bird (a large Andean vulture).[23]

Created to defeat Marxist or left wing radical terrorism (the JCR[24] in particular), the Condor system evolved into a menacing, well organized and state-sponsored terrorist network. The battle against "internal enemies" was extended to all individuals or groups considered

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dangerous and "subversive." The network operated in different phases. The first, as outlined in the November 1975 meeting, was the cooperation between the military intelligence services of the Condor member countries. According to the minutes of the November meeting, this collaboration was designed to ensure "swift and immediate contact when suspicious individuals" were either expelled from the country or traveled outside the country into the territory of another Condor state, "so to alert the Intelligence Services." Moreover, the countries pledged to ameliorate their cryptographic systems, integrate their data banks and facilitate the transmission of information.[25]

During the second phase, Condor was to become operational, with joint actions against selected targets in the member countries of Condor. The result was the tracking, surveillance, interrogation, kidnapping, torture and elimination of alleged opponents. In many cases, these were refugees that had left Chile after 1973, attempting to escape the repression and arrests carried out by the Junta. The United Nations High Commissionar for Refugees (UNHCR) Archives in Geneva has records of the hundreds of individuals that left Chile for fear of political persecution.[26] The cited report of the International Commission of Jurists estimated in 1974 that 150,000 Chileans had left the country as refugees since the coup. Many resettled in Canada, Australia or Europe, but the majority had stayed in Latin America, for the most part in Argentina.

However, after the fall of Isabel Peron's government and General Videla's declaration of the "state of siege" in October 1976, the refugees in Argentina faced similar danger. Already in June 1976 Buenos Aires had announced that among the 20,000 refugees from Chile, Brazil, Uruguay and Bolivia that had emigrated to Argentina there were persons whose continued presence in the country was "not compatible with our internal security."[27] In fact, numerous cables sent to and from the UNHCR headquarters focus on the gravity of the situation of the Chilean refugees in Argentina. In a cable sent to Geneva from New York, "thousands" of people were said to be in danger and had to try to be resettled in the United States. Similarly, the "Swiss Comité pour la Défense des Prisonniers Politiques au Chili" wrote to UNHCR in May 1976 calling for the protection of numerous refugees in Argentina.

The dramatic signal that the exiles were not safe had come already in 1974, with the assassination in Buenos Aires of General Carlos Prats: not a radical leftist guerilla leader, but the former commander of the Chilean armed forces and one of Pinochet's personal rivals. Today, this murder is considered the precursor operation of Condor. At the time, both the Argentine press and CIA reports suggested that the assassination had "to be the work of the Chileans."[28] Moreover, the Chilean newspaper "La Segunda" openly hinted that the murder of Prats might be the first in a series of assassinations of prominent figures residing abroad.[29]

In fact, within two years the Condor network proved the effectiveness of its phase II operations. Exiled Uruguayan legislators Zelmar Michelini and Héctor Gutiérrez Ruiz, who had opposed the military regime and had left Uruguay in 1973 under death threat, were killed in May 1976. Former Bolivian President Juan José Torres Gonzales was also assassinated in Buenos Aires in June 1976. They were all targets and victims of Operation Condor.[30]

The third and most secret "phase III" was the formation of special teams of assassins from Condor member countries to travel outside Latin America to eliminate "subversive enemies." Phase III was aimed at ex-political leaders or prominent influential individuals, potentially capable of mobilizing opposition against the Latin American military regimes.[31]

Collaboration between the Chilean DINA and terrorist organizations, particularly in Europe, predated the formal foundation of Condor. In early 1975, for example, Michael

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Townley, the American expatriate recruited by DINA who had placed and exploded the car bomb that had killed Carlos Prats, was sent to Europe to make as many contacts with anti-communist groups as possible. The objective was to establish DINA "as the principal benefactor in an international war against Marxism."[32] Among his contacts, Townley established ties with the Italian neo-fascist group Avanguardia Nazionale, led by Stefano Delle Chiaie. In the late 1960s and throughout the 1970s, Italy witnessed a severe period of terror—the "Anni di Piombo"—with opposite groups, the Red Brigades on the left and various radical groups such as Avanguardia Nazionale on the right, organizing and excuting terrorist attacks for political purposes. By establishing links with extreme rightist groups in Italy, the Chilean secret service demonstrated its intention to internationalize the fight against communism and globalize its intentions.[33] In July 1975, Della Chiaie participated in the assassination attempt of Bernardo Leighton, a well-known, popular, and active Chilean Christian Democrat living in Rome. Executing orders coming directly from the leadership of the Condor network, on 6 October 1975 Leighton and his wife Anita were shot in Rome—they survived but both had severe and permanent brain damage.

In addition to these high profile assassinations, the Chilean secret services were active and present in Europe also in more subtle ways. For example, various "disquieting" notifications arrived at the UNHCR branch office in Brussels in the fall of 1976. In October, a strictly confidential memorandum was sent to the UNHCR headquarters in Geneva indicating that "Chilean refugees had identified members of the Chilean armed forces or the DINA walking around in Brussels. Some even identified their tortures."[34] Before such incidents were reported to the Belgian police, the story appeared in the French speaking press. An article in "Le Soir" of 24–25 October 1976 was entitled: "La police secrête chilienne opère-t-elle chez nous?" The main informant to the press had been General Poblete, a Chilean refugee well-known to the branch office in Brussels.

In a second cable sent to Geneva, in December 1976, more details were provided. The head of the UNHCR office in Brussels Frank Krenz had met with Poblete to inquire into the allegations of the press. The Chilean refugee stated that he "was absolutely convinced, by the various testimonies he had gathered, that the Chileans in Belgium had been molested and intimidated." When asked why these individuals had not reported directly to the Belgian authorities, Poblete answered that "the refugees were afraid to do so, mostly because they feared a link between Belgian security – CIA – DINA, and that their names be revealed."[35] Therefore, instead of reporting to the police, some of the refugees notified the UNHCR office. One case was the one of a refegee named Medel Shultz. According to Krenz's report, the night after having been interviewed by the Belgian television on her experiences in Chile, four men visited Ms. Shultz's home:

> They rang the door-bell, but the refugee, a woman living alone in an upstairs apartment, did not open the door, controlled by an electronic look, but spoke to the callers through the inter-com. The men, who spoke Spanish, told her that they were aware of her declarations to the television team, and threatened that "something might happen" to her fiancé, Mr Luis Perez Bustos (who was recently released from prison in Chile, and whose renewed disappearance is feared).[36]

The Leighton assassination attempt and the indications of these refugees confirm that DINA and Condor were active and operational in Europe, and not only in Latin America. Moreover, in 1976 Condor surprisingly also reached North America with what has been

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defined as "the most brazen act of international terrorism ever committed in the capital of the United States"[37] before the 11 September 2001 attack on the Pentagon. The target was Orlando Letelier, a long-time friend of Salvador Allende. He had been the Popular Unity's first ambassador to Washington and had then returned to Santiago in May 1973 to become foreign minister of the Allende government. After the coup, Pinochet had ordered that Letelier, together with other prominent figures of the Allende government, be confined in concentration camps. The ex-foreign minister was released after a year of detention, expelled from Chile and subsequently resettled in Washington. At the time of the murder, "he was the most respected and effective spokesman in the international campaign to condemn and isolate the Pinochet dictatorship (…). His efforts to press for Congressional human-rights sanctions aimed at Chile, as well as to lobby UN and European nations to condemn the military regime, established Letelier as Pinochet's most formidable political opponent in exile."[38] With a car bomb explosion on 21 September 1976—only a few blocks away from the White House—Letelier was permanently silenced.

Today, it is more than evident that Operation Condor was a well-coordinated and effective organization, which in more that one occasion succeeded in its missions. What remains less clear is the U.S. stance. As the intelligence structures of the most important military regimes of the Southern Cone cooperated against the communist (or communist perceived) menace, how did the United States react? What was America's attitude towards such manifestly un-democratic means of ensuring hemispheric security of the nation which, in the nineteenth century, had pledged to promote democracy in the Western Hemisphere?

U.S. Knowledge of Condor

In 2000, in a report to Congress, the CIA acknowledged:

> Within a year of the (September 1973 Chilean) coup, the CIA and other US government agencies were aware of bilateral cooperation among regional intelligence services to track the activities of and, in at least a few cases, kill political opponents. This was the precursor to Operation Condor, an intelligence-sharing arrangement among Chile, Argentina, Brazil, Paraguay, and Uruguay established in 1975.[39]

This report reveals that even before the Prats assassination the CIA was aware of the coordination between Latin American countries that was to lead to Condor. The document previously cited, which refers to the Prats assassination as the first in a series of murders as "the work of the Chileans," confirms at least the suspicion, if not U.S. complete knowledge, of Chile's major role in the development of the network. Despite this, in 1974 the American embassy in Santiago refused to accept the possibility that Pinochet's secret police was behind the killing of Prats. U.S. Ambassador David Popper cabled Washington stating: "This makes no sense to us. Nor do we see significant interest in killing Prats of any other Chilean group with capability of doing so."[40] Therefore, as eloquently stated by Peter Kornbluh, while "the Pinochet regime established a precedent for transnational violence that would later reach Washington D.C., the United States made no serious effort to investigate or denounce, publicly or privately, an assassination that the CIA appropriately cataloged in its Weekly Situation Report on International Terrorism."[41]

Moreover, according to J. Patrice McSherry, one of the leading Condor historians, the United States participated in the creation of "Condortel"—the telecommunications system

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employed by Condor to coordinate its data. McSherry states that: "An Argentine military source told a US embassy contact in 1976 that the CIA had played a key role in setting up the computerized links among the intelligence and operations units of the six Condor states."[42] Furthermore, and most surprisingly, the CIA itself revealed (always in 2000) that DINA chief Manuel Contreras had been a CIA asset between 1974 and 1977— precisely the years when he was called "Condor One," the leading proponent and organizer of Condor. Despite the CIA's claim that Contreras was not asked about Condor until after the Letelier assassination in 1976, full light into the relationship between the CIA and the DINA chief has not been shed—and probably never will be since, as asserted by McSherry, the CIA destroyed the file on Contreras in 1991.[43]

Nevertheless, remarkable evidence relating to U.S. knowledge of Condor does exist. For example, in June 1976, Secretary of State Henry Kissinger sent a cable to the the Southern Cone embassies inquiring into the reasons behind the atrocities being perpetuated in Argentina:

> Do you believe that the deaths of political refugees or asylees from your country abroad could have been arranged by your host government through institutional ties to groups, governmental or other, in the country where the deaths took place?
>
> Do you have any evidence to support or deny allegations international arrangements among governments to carry out such assassinations or executions?[44]

A few days later, the embassy in Buenos Aires cabled back stating that: "Elements of the GOA [Government of Argentina] security forces may well have been involved in the murders of Uruguayans Michelini and Gutierrez Riuz and of Bolivian ex-President Torres. Embassy has not positive evidence that this is the case, but there is considerable circumstantial evidence."

The cable in fact continued with details that pointed to the involvement of the Argentinian security forces. It underlined that those who had kidnapped Gutierrez stayed at his home for almost an hour, with no apparent fear of intervention on the part of the police. In the case of Michelini, the police did not even accept the "denuncia" of disappearance made by his wife and made no effort to investigate the crime until several days later. Therefore, on the basis of the information it possessed, the U.S. embassy in Argentina concluded that the security forces were definitely involved, and that they could count on high-level "tolerence." Although the Argentinian government publicly denounced these acts, the cable stressed the continued inertia of General Videla in the investigations on these crimes. Moreover, it affirmed that the Argentinian security forces were "certainly in touch with sister services in neighboring countries and there may well be cooperation among them."[45]

The suspicions of the U.S. embassy were echoed and confirmed by the CIA. A document titled "Latin American Trends," dated 23 June 1976, stated that "the security organizations of several South American countries may be cooperating in actions against political refugees in Argentina." A few weeks later a—heavily excised—CIA weekly summary directly mentions "Condor," not only as a computerized intelligence data bank system, but also as an organization that operated in Argentina, as well as in Europe, to eliminate "subversive" groups. The document also described several operations, such as one that targeted 24 Uruguayan and Chilean refugees in Argentina, kidnapped and tortured for several hours.[46] In a subsequent document, the CIA pointed to "disturbing developments" in the operational attitudes of Operation Condor. While originally designed as a communications system and data

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bank, the organization was "emerging as one with a far more activist role, including specifically that of identifying, locating, and 'hitting' guerrilla leaders."[47]

Even more information on Condor—a 14-page memorandum titled "The Third World War and Latin America" written by assistant secretary of state for Latin America Harry Shlaudeman—was sent to Henry Kissinger on 3 August 1976. This long document described Operation Condor in detail, as well as the "siege mentality" of the military leaders of the countries involved, who thought of themselves as in a "third world war" against communism. The document pointed out how Condor was operational in Latin America and in Europe and underlined that the notion of "subversive" in practice extended to all those who opposed the right-wing governments. Shlaudeman assessed that notions on a "third world war" translated into severe human rights abuses and the implications of such developments were not in the U.S. interest. However, he underlined, Washington's capacity to influence the course of events was in practice limited.[48]

While Shlaudeman's document did not call for any immediate action to thwart Condor plans, three weeks later a State Department cable to the American embassies in the key Southern Cone countries—dated 23 August 1976 and signed by Henry Kissinger—did register the American government's condemnation of state-sponsored assassinations:

> The USG is aware from various sources, including high government officials, that there is a degree of information exchange and coordination among various countries of the Southern Cone with regard to subversive activities within the area. This we consider useful.
>
> There are in addition, however, rumors that this cooperation may extend beyond information exchange to include plans for the assassination of subversive politicians and prominent figures both within the national borders of certain Southern Cone countries and abroad. (…) If these rumors were to have any shred of truth, they would create a most serious moral and political problem.[49]

In this cable, Kissinger instructed the ambassadors to approach the governments involved at the highest levels and express the U.S. "deep concern." In the case of Chile, this meant approaching directly General Pinochet. However, in his response to Kissinger, U.S. Ambassador David Popper underlined Pinochet's "sensitivity regarding pressures from the USG" and recommended, instead, contact between the CIA station chief in Santiago and DINA leader Manuel Contreras. He then asked Washington to send him instructions on if and how to proceed along this line.[50]

There seems to be no evidence of further exchanges for almost a month. Then (and, with hindsight, paradoxically only a few days before the Letelier murder) Henry Kissinger stepped back, in essence contradicting the 23 August document. In a cable sent from Lusaka (where he was visiting) the U.S. secretary of state instructed that "no further action" had to be taken on the issue of Operation Condor. A few days later, Shlaudeman followed up in a cable to the regional ambassadors stating that, since there had been "no reports in some weeks indicating an intention to activate the Condor scheme," action was no longer deemed necessary.[51]

Interestingly, and surprisingly, the response to Ambassador Popper's idea of contact between the CIA and Contreras came only *after* the Letelier assassination. On 4 October 1976 (n.b., six weeks after Popper's request for further instructions and twelve days after the Letelier car bomb) a cable—again signed by Henry Kissinger—was sent from the State Department to Santiago stating: "We agree that our purpose can best be served through

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(CIA Station) approach to Contreras, and that issue should not repeat not be raised with Pinochet."[52]

The American leadership was thus relatively detached and refused to bring the issue up at the highest levels in Chile. This remained the U.S. attitude despite numerous documents describing Operation Condor—including its phase III operations—continued to arrive in Washington (even after the Letelier assassination).[53] For example, a Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) Intelligence Report from U.S. embassy attaché in Buenos Aires Robert Scherrer dated 28 September 1976 stated:

> Operation Condor is the code name for the collection, exchange and storage of intelligence data concerning so-called "leftists," communists and Marxists, which has recently been established between coordinating intelligence services in South America (…) In addition, "Operation Condor" provides for joint operations against terrorist targets in member countries (…). Chile is the center for "Operation Condor" and in addition to Chile its members include Argentina, Bolivia, Paraguay and Uruguay. (…) Members of "Operation Condor" showing the most enthusiasm to date have been Argentina, Uruguay and Chile. The latter three countries have engaged in joint operations, primarily in Argentina, against the terrorist target.

This clearly was an acute description of phase one and two of Condor. Furthermore, the report continued: "A third and most secret phase of "Operation Condor" involves the formation of special teams from member countries who are to travel anywhere in the world to non-member countries to carry out sanctions up to assassination against terrorist or supporters of terrorist organizations (…)."[54]

Thus, also phase III was described, providing details on the methods used by the "special teams" (false documentation issued to travel outside their countries, first the careful surveillance of the target and then the actual mission to eliminate the individuals). Moreover, referring to the murder of Orlando Letelier in Washington, the report unequivocally suggested a possible connection to Condor:

> No information has been developed indicating that sanctions under the third phase of "Operation Condor" have been planned to be carried out in the United States. However, it is not beyond the realm of possibility that the recent assassination of Orlando Letelier in Washington D.C. may have been carried out as a third phase action of "Operation Condor."[55]

Moreover, a secret and still partially censored CIA information cable dated 6 October 1976 pointed directly to Pinochet. The CIA source believed "that the Chilean government was directly involved in Letelier's death."[56]

From the evidence cited, it emerges with clarity that the Ford administration witnessed the creation and operational effectiveness of Condor without taking strong actions neither to stop its plans, nor to openly condemn their outcomes. Remarkably, this remained the U.S. stance despite the establishment of the Senate Select Committee on Intelligence, created in 1975 and chaired by Democratic senator Frank Church. Following revelations published in the press concerning the activities of the CIA, including covert operations aimed at subverting foreign governments, the Church Committee's mission was to investigate the legality and morality of such actions. U.S. policies toward Vietnam, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, the Dominican Republic and Cuba were scrutizined, with particular attention given to the allegations of American involvement in the 1973 Chilean coup (and previous attempts to destabilize the Chilean economy). The Committee produced reports on abuses of power and recommended reforms, only in part implemented in the following years.[57] In general, in

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the second half of the 1970s, the issue of human rights and the need for a more "moral" foreign policy powerfully emerged and increasingly came to dominate the American political scene. This shift, however, did not translate into open condemnation of the Condor network, which continued to operate undisturbed.

The cases against Henry Kissinger in particular, regarding Condor and other human rights abuses, have in fact been numerous[58]—with the emblematic definition of the ex-secretary of state as "a war criminal" by Christopher Hitchens.[59] But as the American government shifted from the declared realpolitik of the Nixon–Kissinger–Ford era to the open emphasis on the respect and promotion of human rights of the Carter administration, what was the U.S. leadership's attitude toward Condor and its related crimes? Did Carter's promise to refocus American foreign policy on democratic principles and moral values translate into significant changes toward the abuses perpetuated in the Southern Cone countries, Chile in particular?

U.S. Failure to React

During the Carter administration, the overall human rights situation in the key Condor countries remained extremely worrisome. Various letters from human rights groups were sent to the UNHCR headquarters underlining that "the fate of Chilean political refugees in Argentina continued to be a matter of deep concern."[60] Despite the difficult situation they continued to face, in November 1978 UNHCR estimated that 8,500 Chilean citizens were still present in Argentina.[61]

The UNHCR office in Buenos Aires therefore continued to handle numerous cases. For example, the case of 13 Chilean citizens abducted in the streets of Santiago and since then disappeared. The Pinochet regime claimed that these individuals had left Chile for Argentina, but there were serious doubts that this had indeed occurred. The UNCHR regional representative in fact wrote to the headquarters in Geneva:

> Their (of the 13 disappeared) families, as well as the lawyers, are persuaded that these people in fact never crossed the border and are either detained or dead in Chile. In their opinion, other persons took the identity papers of these Communist leaders and crossed the border so as to give the impression that they left the country on their own.[62]

The UNHCR official continued his report by expressing serious reservations on the possibility of obtaining any information on the fate of these individuals from the Chilean government. This (and other documents) confirmed that the political persecutions continued. In this case the individuals were communists, but there was evidence also of a number of Christian Democrats "*relegados*" in the North of Chile.[63]

As the Southern Cone military regimes' crude methods to protect their internal security evidently continued, so did the cooperation between their secret services through the Condor network. Consequently, in early 1977—at the beginning of the Carter administration—the question on what should be the U.S. stance was raised within the American intelligence community: "It would be helpful to have an update on the subject of Condor, what we know about it, and how we should deal with the knowledge we have. We might want to think again about whether we should raise the subject with the governments involved."[64]

The continued operational effectiveness of Condor (and American high-level knowledge and complicity) is further confirmed by a cable sent to Secretary of State Cyrus Vance from

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the U.S. ambassador to Paraguay Robert White in October 1978: "They (the Condor countries) keep in touch with one another thorough a U.S. communications installation in the Panama Canal zone which covers all of Latin America. (…) They maintain the confidentiality of their communication through the U.S. facility in Panama by using bilateral codes."[65]

The ambassador concluded the cable suggesting that it would "seem advisable to review this arrangement to ensure that its continuation is in US interest" but, according to McSherry, he never received a response.[66]

The Carter administration, in fact, never developed an active stance against the continuation of the abuses of Operation Condor. Nor did it adopt effective measures to thwart its further expansion. Emblematic, in this context, was the fact that in September 1977 President Carter invited General Pinochet to Washington to join the other Latin American leaders for the signing of the Panama Canal Treaties, despite the unchanged human rights situation in Chile. According to the memorandum of the private conversation between Carter and Pinochet, the American president only marginally raised human rights issues, while declaring instead that he "did not want anything to stand in the way of traditional US-Chilean friendship."[67]

More specifically, in relation to Operation Condor, President Carter was presented with a unique opportunity to demonstrate his actual, and not simply declared, commitment to the defense of human rights. Predictibly, the developments in the investigation of the Letelier murder increasingly pointed to the responsibility of the Chilean Junta. In April 1978, Michael Townley was arrested by the FBI. Under interrogation, he provided details of the assassination plot and implicated the highest officials of DINA. Consequently, Washington formally requested the extradition of Manuel Contreras, his deputy and other key DINA members.[68] However, in order to avoid the direct link to himself, Pinochet successfully maneuvered to deny the responsibility of his secret police.[69] On 13 May 1979 the Chilean Supreme Court, on the basis that Townley's confession had been a "paid accusation," denied the U.S. extradition request. While the U.S. Justice Department investigators argued for a forceful response to protest against this decision, the State Department insisted in putting the "matter in the context of the entire range of bilateral relations with Chile."[70]

In fact, with the exception of the State Department's Office of Human Rights and Humanitarian Affairs, which sought strong retaliatory measures against Chile, the U.S. leadership did not resolutely demand accountability of those responsible for the Letelier assassination. By 1979 numerous U.S. sources unequivocally pointed to the Pinochet regime as the coordinator of an act of state-sponsored terrorism on American soil.[71] Nonotheless, the crime was in essence condoned. A series of sanctions against Chile were approved, but clearly in a context in which the Carter administration was cautious not to compromise the broader spectrum of U.S.–Chilean relations.[72]

As a result, the Condor network continued undisturbed to operate also throughout the Carter years. Although there are no known cases of phase III assassinations, the permanent disappearance of individuals in South America remained a constant practice, well known to Washington. For example, a report of a regional security officer (RSO), declassified in 2002, reveals that his office in Buenos Aires had prior knowledge of the planned "permanent disappearance" of Noemi Gianetti de Molfino and other three individuals in 1980. In his report to the U.S. ambassador, the RSO cited a meeting with an Argentine military security officer during which he had been informed that the four disappeared persons "will be held in Peru and then expelled to Bolivia where they

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will be expelled to Argentina. Once in Argentina they will be interrogated and then permanently disappeared."[73] This was clearly a Condor operation involving the intelligence services of three countries and an American official had been briefed on it *before* its implementation. The plan was executed (Gianetti de Molfino's body was later found) and was to become, in the mid-1990s, the first case in which the Argentine government recognized responsibility for a Condor crime.

In this and in other cases evidence demonstrates that American officials also during the Carter administration had knowledge of severe human rights crimes operated under the Condor scheme, but failed to react. As in the case of the Letelier murder, these crimes were deliberately kept on a low profile even by the so-called human rights administration of Jimmy Carter. U.S. high-level knowledge of Condor and of General Pinochet's direct involvement in blatant acts of state-sponsored terrorism, such as the Letelier assassination, has also been recently confirmed by the declassification of documents pertaining to the Reagan administration. In October 1987, Secretary of State George Shultz in fact wrote to President Reagan stating that the CIA had "convincing evidence" that Pinochet "personally ordered" the killing of Orlando Letelier in Washington. "Pinochet decided to stonewall on the US investigation to hide his involvement," the document reads, and as part of the cover-up considered "even the elimination of his former intelligence chief," DINA director Manuel Contreras, who had overseen the assassination plot. Shultz underlined that the "CIA has never before drawn and presented its conclusion that such strong evidence exists of his (Pinochet's) leadership role in this act of terrorism." Consequently, the U.S. secretary of state urged the president to reconsider U.S. ties with Pinochet and to press toward the complete democratization of Chile.

As we now know, U.S. ties with Chile and with other regimes of the Southern Cone were not seriously reconsidered until well after the end of the Cold War when, in any case, democratic transitions ended the rule of the right-wing military dictatorships. As a result, Augusto Pinochet (and Paraguaian leader Alfredo Stroessner) died without ever being accountable for crimes related to Condor, thus never answering questions on the fate of the countless "disappeared" whose memory continues to haunt thousands of Latin American families.

Conclusion

The full role of the CIA and of the United States in the obscure story of Condor is difficult to determine, at least on the basis of the sources currently available. In any case, it is unlikely that a document will ever emerge that will unequivocally point to direct American responsabilities. This, however, may be besides the point. Ambiquity, in the face of thousands of disappearances, kidnappings, tortures, and murders—of "ordinary" individuals as well as of the high-profile cases mentioned here—is, in any case, a form of complicity. Although Washington's capacity to influence events—as effectively underlined by Shlaudeman in one of his memorandums—was limited, failure to energetically condemn the perpetuation of crimes and abuses is, in one way or another, equivalent to tacit approval. Blinded by Cold War imperatives, the United States did not want to antagonize the right-wing governments of the Southern Cone countries, first and foremost Pinochet's Chile. This at the cost of accepting, and sometimes promoting—as stated back in the 1950s—extremely "repugnant philosophies."

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The high-profile assassinations attibuted to Condor—from Carlos Prats to Orlando Letelier—have become well-known today, and have captured the attention of scholars focusing on Latin America and terrorism in the late 1970s. This article has built on previous literature and, on the basis of the latest declassified documents on these assassinations, has highlighted Washington's tacit approval for state-sponsored terrorism in the countries of the Southern Cone. The question as to what Washington gained by supporting countries that derided the professed ideals of the United States remains, however, to a large extent unanswered.

But the intention here was to go a step further. By integrating the story of the high-profile assassinations and the top-level knowledge or acquiescence of the U.S. government with that of "ordinary" refugees, the scope was to depicit a broader and deeper picture of what Condor was and how it functioned. The documents from the United Nations High Commissioner for Reguees—an intergovermental agency that did not have a role or agenda, but whose mandate was to protect the refugees—reveal that Condor was capable of reaching far beyond the borders of Latin America in its search for potential enemies of the state. And its targets were not just high-profile politicians, but ordinary citizens. The accounts of the harassements of Chilean refugees in Belgium and their fear of collusions between the Western security forces (Belgian and CIA) and the DINA are, in this regard, particularly telling. The story of Condor, and of the U.S. role in supporting this network, is as much about these "ordinary" people as it is about high-profile assassinations.

American support for right-wing authoritarian regimes in Latin America has always been morally questionable, despite the moral arguments used by U.S. leaders to gather support for such policies within the Cold War context. The broader struggle with the Soviet Union and the need to contain and, at times, reverse the advance of communism was used to justify the oppression of people, as economic assistance, military equipment, and political legitimacy was granted to various Latin American despots. Within this framework, the focus of this article—Operation Condor—was a relatively minor episode, that fitted into the much larger scope of America's Cold War policy in the Western Hemisphere. But it was a small episode that impacted the lives of thousands of people, and that—in the words of Senator Frank Church—"grieviosly impaired the good name of the United States."[74] This, more than anything else, may be the enduring legacy of the U.S. association with Condor.

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Notes

1. Cecilia Menjivar and Nestor Rodriguez, "State Terror in the U.S.-Latin American Interstate Regime," in Cecilia Menjivar and Nestor Rodriguez, eds., *When States Kill. Latin America, the U.S. and Technologies of Terror* (Austin: University of Texas Press, 2005), pp. 8–10.
2. Menjivar and Rodriguez, *When States Kill*, p. 8.
3. Peter Smith, *Talons of the Eagle. Dynamics of U.S.-Latin American Relations* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2000), p. 124.
4. Foreign Relations of the United States documents pertaining to the Eisenhower administratration quoted in Richard H. Immerman, *The CIA in Guatemala. The Foreign Policy of Intervention* (Austin: University of Texas Press, 1982), pp. 8–9.
5. Smith, *Talons of the Eagle*, p. 124.
6. Ibid., p. 126.
7. Ibid., p. 127.

8. For more on Guatemala, see, for example, Immerman, *The CIA in Guatemala* and Nick Cullanther, *Secret History: The CIA's Classified Account of Its Operations in Guatemala, 1952–1954* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1999).
9. Quoted in Tim Weiner, *Legacy of Ashes. The History of the CIA* (New York: Doubleday, 2007), p. 109.
10. On the failure of the CIA at the Bay of Pigs, see Weiner, *Legacy of Ashes*, pp. 173–179.
11. For more on the U.S. intervention in British Guyana, see John Prados, *Safe for Democracy. The Secret Wars of the CIA* (Chicago: Ivan R. Dee, 2006), pp. 3–19.
12. "Kennedy Address to the Nation, October 22, 1962." Transcript available at http://www.let.rug.nl/usa/presidents/john-fitzgerald-kennedy/address-by-president-kennedy-october-22-1962.php (accessed May 11, 2015)
13. The literature on the Cuban missile crisis is massive. See, for example, James Blight, Bruce Allyn, and David Welch, *Cuba on the Brink. Castro, the Missile Crisis and the Soviet Collapse* (Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, 2002) and Alexandr Fursenko and Timothy Naftali, *One Hell of a Gamble: Khrushchev, Castro, and Kennedy, 1958–1964: The Secret History of the Cuban Missile Crisis* (New York: W. W. Norton & Company, 1998).
14. George Kennan quoted in Smith, *Talons of the Eagle,* p. 127.
15. See David F. Schmitz, *Thank God They Are On Our Side: The United States and Right-Wing Dictatorships, 1921–1965* (Chapel Hill: The University of North Carolina Press, 1999).
16. Henry Kissinger, *Years of Upheaval* (London: Phoenix Press, 2000), pp. 374–414.
17. On U.S. relations with Chile see, for example, Tanja Tarmer, *Allende's Chile and the Inter-American Cold War* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2011) and Jonathan Haslam, *The Nixon Administration and the Death of Allende's Chile: A Case of Assisted Suicide* (London: Verso, 2005).
18. John Dinges defines Operation Condor as a "transnational anti-communist war apparatus" in *The Condor Years. How Pinochet and His Allies Brought Terrorism to Three Continents* (New York: The New Press, 2004).
19. J. Patrice McSherry, "Operation Condor as a Hemispheric 'Counter-Terror' Organization," in Cecilia Menjivar and Nestor Rodriguez, eds., *When States Kill. Latin America, the U.S. and Technologies of Terror* (Austin: University of Texas Press, 2005), p. 32.
20. "Life in Chile under the Military Dictatorship," Report no. 2, November 1974, Chile Committee for Human Rights in United Nations High Commission for Refugees (UNHCR) Archives, box 19, folder Refugees from Chile-General, doc. 17, pp. 1–2.
21. Ibid., p. 3.
22. DINA secret summary, "Closing Statement of the First Inter-American Meeting of National Intelligence," November 28, 1975 in Peter Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File. A Declassified Dossier on Atrocity and Accountability* (New York: The New Press, 2003), appendix to chapter 6, doc. 2.
23. Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, p. 323 and McSherry, "Operation Condor as a Hemispheric 'Counter-Terror' Organization," p. 38.
24. This translates as the "Revolutionary Coordinating Junta." It is important to note that in May 1975 the arrest of the leaders of this marxist movement—Jorge Fuentes Alarcón and Amilcar Santucho—is consderted the first episode of cooperation between the secret services of the Southern Cone states that would lead to the system named Condor; John Dinges, "Pulling Back the Veil On Condor," *The Nation*, 13 July 2000.
25. DINA secret summary, "Closing Statement of the First Inter-American Meeting of National Intelligence," 28 November 1975 in Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File,* p. 355.
26. Documents can be found at: UNHCR Archives, boxes 19, 38, 46, 48, 50, 51, 54, 62, 72, 73, 80, 83, 87, 89, 95, 103, 109, 125, 132, 134, 156, 157, 161, 164, 185, 185, 207, 211. These contain information on the individuals that left Chile throughout the 1970s. The majority stayed in Latin America, relocating in Argentina, Brazil, Bolivia, Cuba, Columbia, Costa Rica, Equador, Guatemala, Mexico, Peru and Venezuela. Others moved to Europe, in Austria, Belgium, France, Germany, the United Kingdom, Ireland, Portugal, Italy, Sweden, and Switzerland. Some moved to Canada or New Zeland.
27. UNHCR incoming cable (from New York to Geneva)—report of Juan de Onis, translated and published by the *New York Times* on 27 June 1976; UNHCR Archives, box 48, folder Refugees in Argentina-General 1976-1977 Vol. 3, doc 72.

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28. CIA Secret Intelligence Report (Assassination of General Carlos Prats), 25 October 1976 in Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, p. 9.
29. "Life in Chile under the Military Dictatorship," p. 9.
30. J. Patrice McSherry, "The Undead Ghost of Condor." Available at www.logosjournal.com/issue_4.2/mcsherry.htm, p. 6 (accessed June 2, 2015).
31. For more on Operation Condor: J. Patrice McSherry, *Predatory States. Operation Condor and Covert War in Latin America* (Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, 2005).
32. Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, p. 332.
33. On the Anni di Piombo, see (in Italian): Indro Montanelli and Mario Cervi, *L'Italia degli anni di piombo* (Milano: Rizzoli, 1991). On U.S. involvement in Italy in those years, see Maurizio Molinari: *Governo ombra: i documenti Segreti degli USA sull'Italia negli anni di piombo* (Milano: Rizzoli, 2012).
34. Memorandum (Strictly Confidential) to UNHCR Headquarters Geneva from Frank. E. Krenz "Presence of Chilean Secret Services in Brussels," 26 October, 1976, UNHCR Archives, box 54, folder Refugees from Chile to Belgium, doc. 7.
35. Memorandum (Strictly Confidential) to UNHCR Headquarters Geneva from Frank. E. Krenz "Presence Chilean Secret Services in Brussels," 15 December 1976, UNHCR Archives, box 54, folder Refugees from Chile to Belgium, doc. 8.
36. Memorandum (Strictly Confidential) to UNHCR Headquarters Geneva from Frank. E. Krenz "Presence of Chilean Secret Services in Brussels," 15 December 1976.
37. Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, p. 341.
38. Ibid., pp. 341–342.
39. McSherry, "Operation Condor as a Hemispheric 'Counter-Terror' Organization," in *When States Kill*, p. 39.
40. Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, p. 327.
41. Ibid.
42. J. Patrice McSherry, "Operation Condor: Deciphering U.S. Role." Available at https://www.globalpolicy.org/component/content/article/168/28173.html (accessed June 5, 2015).
43. Ibid.
44. Department of State, Action Cable, "Possible International Implications of Violent Deaths of Political Figures Abroad," 4 June 1976 in Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, appendix to chapter 6, doc. 12.
45. Department of State Telegram from Embassy Buenos Aires to SecState Washington, 7 June 1976, the National Security Archive.
46. CIA Latin American Trends, June 23, 1976 and CIA Weekly Summary, 2 July 1976, the National Security Archive.
47. Department of State Secret Minutes, "ARA-CIA Weekly Meeting—30 July 1976, Operation Condor," 3 August 1976 in Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, appendix to chapter 6, doc. 13.
48. Memorandum from Harry W. Shlaudeman to the Secretary (Kissinger), 3 August 1976, the National Security Archive.
49. Department of State, Secret Roger Channel Cable, "Operation Condor," 23 August 1976 in Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, appendix to chapter 6, doc. 15.
50. Telegram from U.S. Embassy Santiago to SecState, 24 August 1976, the National Security Archive.
51. Department of State, Secret Cable from Assistant Secretary Harry Shlaudeman, "Operation Condor," 20 September 1976 in Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, appendix to chapter 6, doc. 17.
52. Telegram from SecState Washington to US Embassy Santiago, 1 October 1976, the National Security Archive.
53. The National Security Archive has documents dated 24 September 1976 and 28 September 1976, for example.
54. FBI Intelligence Report from Attaché Robert Scherrer (Letelier-Moffitt Assassination and Operation Condor), 28 September 1976 in Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, appendix to chapter 6, doc. 11.
55. Ibid.
56. CIA, Secret Intelligence Information Cable (Assassination of Orlando Letelier), 6 October 1976 in Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, appendix to chapter 6, doc. 19.

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57. Schmitz, *Thank God They Are on Our Side*, pp. 294–300.
58. Kissinger is suspected of having been deeply and directly involved with some of the Condor crimes. Judges in France, Chile, and Argentina have requested his testimony in various cases. In 2002, Chilean lawyers have filed a formal criminal complaint against the ex-Secretary of State.
59. Christopher Hitchens, *The Trial of Henry Kissinger* (London: Verso, 2002).
60. Letter to High Commission for Refugees from Sylvain Bromberger (New York), 13 March 1977, UNHCR Archives, box 48, folder Refugees from Chile in Argentina Vol. 2, doc. 67.
61. Letter to Inga (UNHCR Geneva) from Norma Fraser (Resettlement Officer), 24 November 1978, UNHCR Archives, box 48, folder Refugees from Chile in Argentina Vol. 2, doc. 103.
62. Memorandum (strictly confidential) to UNHCR Headquarters from Robert J. Muller, Regional Representative, "Disappearance of 13 Chilean Citizens," 2 March, 1977, UNHCR Archives, box 48, folder Refugees from Chile in Argentina Vol. 2, doc. 65.
63. Memorandum to UNHCR Headquarters from UNHCR Sub-Office Santiago, Chile, 9 February 1978, UNHCR Archives, box 48, folder Refugees from Chile in Argentina Vol. 3, doc. 407.
64. Memorandum for the Record of ACA/CIA Weekly Meeting, 4 March 1977, the National Security Archive.
65. Telegram from U.S. Embassy Asuncione to SecState WasgDC "Second Meeting with Chief of Staff RE Letelier Case," October 1978, National Security Archive.
66. McSherry, "Operation Condor: Deciphering U.S. Role."
67. Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, p. 396.
68. Ibid., p. 397.
69. For the reconstruction of the cover up, see Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, pp. 397–407. For a detailed account of the Letelier investigation, see John Dinges and Saul Landau, *Assassination on Embassy Row* (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1981).
70. Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, p. 404.
71. For example, see ibid., pp. 400 and 402.
72. Secretary of State, Options Paper for President Carter from Cyrus Vance, "Letelier-Moffitt Case," 19 October 1979 in Kornbluh, *The Pinochet File*, appendix to chapter 7, doc. 4. This document describes the sanctions recommended by Vance and approved by Carter. Interestingly, Vance himself opposed drastic sanctions. In essence, the sanctions approved were largely symbolic and the more "extreme measures" were ruled out.
73. Quoted in McSherry, "Operation Condor as a Hemispheric 'Counter-Terror' Organization," p. 48.
74. Quoted in Schmitz, *Thank God They Are on Our Side*, p. 300.

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